FREE BOOK

Making and Keeping Friends

What friendship looks like, how it grows, how to tell a good friend from someone who uses you, and what to do when things go wrong.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children, young people and adults, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary (senior classes) · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA

Easy read

A friend is a person who likes you. A good friend is kind to you. You can have one friend or many friends.

How to use this resource

- Read one section at a time, at a calm time. You do not need to finish the book in one go.
- Do the activities with a trusted adult or a friend. Tick, circle or write in the boxes.
- Practise the scripts out loud before you need them. Saying them first makes them easier later.
- Print the sorting page (good friend or not a friend) and keep it in a school bag or on a bedroom wall.
- Use the **Notes for adults** boxes to talk through the ideas. Friendship is learned in many ways, and every way counts.

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Version 1.0 · making-and-keeping-friends

1. What is a friend?

A friend is a person you like and who likes you. Friends choose to spend time with each other. Friends do not have to look the same, be the same age or like the same things.

- A friend likes being with me.
- A friend is kind to me, and I am kind back.
- Friends talk, play, work or just sit together.
- I can say yes or no to a friend.

Different kinds of friendship

Best friend

Someone you trust a lot and see often.

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School friend

Someone you like to be with in class or at break.

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Family friend

A cousin, neighbour or a friend your family knows.

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Online friend

Someone you talk to through a game or an app. See section 8.

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Shared-interest friend

Someone who likes the same thing as you, such as trains, drawing or football.

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Friendly person

Someone you say hello to. They are kind, but not yet a friend.

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Notes for adults

- Do not define friendship by numbers or by how much eye contact or small talk a young person uses. Ask what the friendship is like for them.
- Autistic people often make friends differently: through shared interests, parallel play, messages or doing an activity side by side. These are real friendships.
- Some autistic young people want many friends, some want one, and some want time on their own. All of these are fine.

2. How friendship grows

Most friendships grow in small steps, like climbing a ladder. You do not have to hurry. You can stay on a step for as long as you like, and you can go back down a step.



Step 1: Say hello

Smile or say hello. Use their name if you know it. Example: 'Hi, Sam.'



Step 2: Small chat

Ask one question or share one fact. Example: 'Did you play that game at the weekend?'



Step 3: Do something together

Sit together, play a game, or work on a project in school. Doing a thing together is easier than only talking.



Step 4: Choose each other

You pick each other for teams, you save a seat, or you message each other first.



Step 5: Make a plan

Agree to meet or play online at a set time. Example: 'Will we play on Saturday at 3?'



Step 6: Trust

You can share a worry, a secret or a feeling. You know they will be kind.

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Friendship takes time.



I can go back a step if I need a break.

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My friendship ladder

A person I say hello to: _____

A person I chat with: _____

A person I do something with: _____

A person I trust: _____

Notes for adults

- A good first target is one more step, not a best friend. Practise with someone the young person already knows and likes.
- Shared interest clubs (Lego, art, coding, chess, nature, gaming) at school or in the community give a built-in reason to talk.

3. Good friend or not a friend?

Some people are kind and safe. Some people are not. Read each box. Then talk about a time you saw each one. Remember: you did nothing wrong if someone treats you badly.

A good friend

- Is kind to me
- Stops when I say stop
- Is OK when I say no
- Likes me as I am
- Says sorry when they get it wrong
- Keeps my private things private
- Is happy for me to have other friends

Not a friend

- Is mean, hits or laughs at me
- Keeps going after I say stop
- Gets cross when I say no
- Takes my things or my money
- Tells me to keep a secret that worries me
- Shares my private things or photos
- Is only nice when they want something

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A good friend makes me feel safe.

If I feel scared or sick, I tell an adult I trust.

4. Someone who uses you

Sometimes a person pretends to be a friend so they can use you. This is sometimes called **mate crime**. It can happen to anyone. It is never your fault. The person doing it is the one who is wrong.

Warning signs

They ask for money or things

They borrow and do not give it back, or ask you to buy things for them.

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They say 'Do not tell anyone'

A good friend is OK with you telling a trusted adult.

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They dare you to do bad things

Such as taking things, breaking rules or hurting someone.

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They keep you away from others

They say your family and other friends are 'bad' for you.

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They make you feel bad

You feel worried, small or scared after you see them.

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They want your passwords or photos

Never share these. See section 8.

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What to do

They ask to borrow money again

No. I am not lending money.

They say 'Do not tell anyone'

I am going to tell my Mum. I always tell someone I trust.

They keep pushing you

I said no. I am going now.

1. Say no, or walk away.
2. Tell an adult you trust. Keep telling until someone listens.
3. Keep any messages. They can help adults to help you.
4. If you are in danger, ring 112 or 999.

Notes for adults

- Autistic people are more likely to be targeted by people who want to use them, partly because many are taught to be compliant and to trust literal statements. Teach that **friends do not ask you to break rules, hide things or give them money**.
- Teach 'Nothing is so awful that we can't talk about it with someone we trust.' Name at least three trusted adults together.
- If you think a young person is being exploited, follow your school's Child Protection Procedures (Designated Liaison Person) or contact Tusla, and the Gardaí if there is a crime or danger. For an adult, contact the Gardaí.

5. Starting a conversation

Starting a chat can feel hard. You can use a script. A script is words you have practised. Everybody uses them, and they are not cheating. Pick one and say it out loud three times.



Say hello

'Hi, I am ___. What is your name?'

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Ask about something

'Do you like ___? I like it too.'

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Pay a compliment

'I like your bag.' or 'Your drawing is good.'

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Join in

'Can I play too?' Wait for the answer. Be OK with yes or no.

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Ask for help

'Can you show me how to do this?'

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Make a plan

'Do you want to play on Saturday at 3?'

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Reading the answer

If they say 'yes' or 'OK', carry on.

If they say 'no', say 'OK' and try another day or another person.

If I am not sure, I can ask: 'Do you want to talk, or not now?'

Notes for adults

- Practise in role-play with a safe adult, then with a peer. Swap roles so the young person also practises being the one who is asked.
- A 'no' is not a failure. Teach that everyone gets a no sometimes, and that it does not mean 'there is something wrong with you'.

6. When a friendship goes wrong

Friends sometimes fall out. It is normal. Many friendships can be repaired, and some end. Both are OK.

1

Calm down

Take a break. Breathe. Do not message when you are very upset.

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2

Think

What happened? What did I do? What did they do?

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3

Say sorry, if you did something

'I am sorry I shouted. I was upset.'

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4

Say what you need

'I did not like it when you ___. Please do not do it again.'

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5

Give it time

They may need a day or two. Do not keep pushing.

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Ask for help

A teacher, SNA or parent can help you to talk it through.

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You got something wrong

I am sorry. I did not mean to upset you.

They did something that hurt you

That hurt me. I need you to stop.

You want to make up

I miss being friends. Do you want to play on Saturday?

Saying sorry is brave.

If a friend is not kind, I can leave the friendship.

Notes for adults

- Autistic young people can find it very upsetting when friends are angry, or when they do not understand why. Help them to work out facts: who said what, and what each person might have felt.
- Bullying is different from falling out. If it is repeated, deliberate and hurtful, follow your school's anti-bullying procedures.

7. It is OK to have a few friends

You do not need lots of friends. One good friend can be enough. Some people like quiet time on their own. That is not sad or wrong. It is a choice.

One good friend

Quality matters more than quantity.

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Friends through interests

Clubs, teams, games, art, trains, animals or music can bring friends together.

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Time on my own

Alone time helps many people to feel calm again.

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Family and helpers

Family, SNAs and teachers can also be warm and kind people in your life.

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About me

Things I like: _____

A club or group I could try: _____

How much time I like to spend with people: _____

A person I feel safe with: _____

Notes for adults

- Do not pressure young people to 'socialise more' without asking what they want. Loneliness is real, and so is the need for rest.
- Ask: 'Do you want more friends, or are you happy as you are?' Plan support only for what they want.

8. Online friends

Many people make friends online, through games or interests. Online friends can be real friends. But online is also public, and you cannot always know who someone is.

Safe to do

- Chat about games and hobbies
- Use a nickname, not your full name
- Block and report people who are unkind
- Tell a trusted adult who you talk to

Not safe

- Sharing your address, school or phone number
- Sending photos of your body
- Sharing passwords
- Keeping the friendship a secret from your family

Meeting an online friend

- Do not meet an online friend in person unless a trusted adult knows and agrees.
- Meet in a public place, with an adult close by.
- Tell the adult where you are going, who you are meeting and when you will be home.

Notes for adults

- Sharing, or threatening to share, an intimate image of someone without consent is a crime in Ireland (Harassment, Harmful Communications and Related Offences Act 2020, 'Coco's Law'). Sexual images of anyone under 18 are child sexual abuse material, even if the young person made the image. Teach: tell a trusted adult, do not forward it. Report images at hotline.ie.
- Online safety advice for parents and teachers: webwise.ie.
- Ask about online friends with interest, not alarm. Young people who feel judged stop telling.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself and Others**, strand unit *My friends and other people*; and strand **Myself and the Wider World**, *Media education*.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 1 *Understanding Myself and Others* and Strand 3 *Relationships and Sexuality*: friendship, respect, trust, communication and healthy relationships.
- Senior Cycle SPHE: new specification published 2024, being introduced for fifth years, including relationships learning. Leaving Certificate Applied: Social Education.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Tusla – Child and Family Agency

Report a worry about a child's safety to your local Tusla social work duty team. Contacts at tusla.ie.

Webwise

Online safety advice for parents, teachers and young people at webwise.ie.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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